

Bangladesh's Current Situation: Problems and Solutions

Authored by: Mohammad Sheikh Shahinur Rahman, ORCID:
<https://orcid.org/0009-0002-5025-6138>

1. Executive Summary

Since its independence, Bangladesh has made significant socio-economic progress, transforming from one of the world's poorest countries to a lower-middle-income nation. This progress is a testament to the country's resilience, strategic policy decisions, and commitment to poverty reduction and shared prosperity. However, in recent times, Bangladesh has faced several complex challenges that are impacting its development trajectory. High inflation, investment crises, and rising unemployment threaten the country's economic stability. Socially, increasing poverty, income inequality, and disparities in the quality and access to education and healthcare have become prominent. A lack of good governance, particularly widespread corruption and political instability, poses significant obstacles to economic and social progress. Furthermore, natural disasters caused by climate change and rising sea levels are having severe negative impacts on the country's environment and livelihoods. This report provides a detailed analysis of Bangladesh's current situation, existing problems, and effective and practical solutions for sustainable development. By achieving economic stability, ensuring inclusive social development, establishing good governance, enhancing climate resilience, and accelerating digital transformation, Bangladesh will be able to achieve its desired goals.

2. Introduction: Bangladesh's Current Context

Over the past four decades since its independence, Bangladesh has witnessed an extraordinary transformation. Once known as one of the world's poorest countries, Bangladesh has now achieved lower-middle-income status. This transformation is a shining example of the resilience of its people, far-sighted policy decisions, and the government's firm commitment to poverty reduction and collective prosperity. Bangladesh's economy is transitioning from primarily agrarian to manufacturing-based, characterized by moderate annual growth, reduced reliance on foreign aid, and rapid growth in the service sector. However, this journey of progress has not been smooth. Multidimensional challenges such as global economic downturns, internal political instability, and climate change have continuously affected Bangladesh's development efforts. This report provides a detailed analysis of Bangladesh's current situation, including economic, social, political, and environmental challenges, and effective solutions for sustainable development. Its aim is to present a comprehensive picture that will assist policymakers, researchers, and all relevant stakeholders in making strategic decisions.

3. Overall Situation Analysis

3.1 Economic Landscape

While Bangladesh's economic growth has been commendable in recent years, it has recently faced challenges due to some internal and global adversities.

GDP Growth and Industrial Sector

In 2023, Bangladesh's nominal GDP was US\$420.52 billion, making it the 37th largest economy in the world. On a PPP (Purchasing Power Parity) basis, its GDP was US\$1.48 trillion, ranking 25th. GDP growth was 7.1% in 2022, an estimated 5.5% in 2023, and an estimated 6.5% in 2024. The country's industrial sector contributed 29.54% to GDP in the 2020 fiscal year. However, the growth of the industrial sector has significantly declined due to the COVID-19 pandemic and the subsequent Russia-Ukraine war. Industrial sector growth was 10.29% in FY2020-21, which fell to 6.66% in FY2022-23. Production further decreased in FY2023-24. This continuous decline indicates a significant structural challenge beyond immediate global events. The initial decline was linked to the COVID-19 pandemic, which was later exacerbated by the Russia-Ukraine war. However, the continuous decline in FY2023-24 points to deeper problems. It is directly linked to the 'deterioration of the investment climate' and 'dollar shortages' for raw material imports. This means that external shocks have exposed and worsened pre-existing weaknesses in the industrial sector, rather than being the sole cause of the decline. High business costs, such as gas and electricity shortages, high bank interest rates, and lack of cooperation from banks, further complicate the problem.

The government has set a GDP growth target of 6.75% for FY2024-25. However, the Asian Development Bank (ADB) has lowered its GDP growth forecast for Bangladesh to 3.9% from 4.3% for FY2024-25, citing economic challenges, political uncertainty, and high inflation. They expect 5.1% growth in FY2025-26. According to the International Monetary Fund (IMF) report, GDP growth fell to 3.3% in the first half of FY2024-25 from 5.1% in the same period of FY2023-24, due to popular uprising, tighter policies, and investment uncertainty. This significant discrepancy between government targets and independent forecasts (ADB, IMF) indicates over-optimism in government projections or insufficient accounting for recent economic and political instability. The ADB directly attributed its lower forecast to "political uncertainty" and "persistent economic challenges", while the IMF cited "economic disruptions caused by the popular uprising, a tighter policy mix, and heightened uncertainty that weighed on investment". This means that political instability and its side effects (e.g., impact on investment, worker protests) are now a major impediment to economic performance, making it difficult for the government to achieve its development targets. The main drivers of GDP (manufacturing, wholesale and retail trade, transport, construction, and agriculture) are sensitive to such instability.

Inflation and Purchasing Power

Inflation is a persistent and growing concern for Bangladesh's economy. CPI inflation was 9.94% in May 2023. The average inflation for the recently concluded FY2023-24 was 9.73%. The World Bank forecasts that inflation will remain around 10% in the current fiscal year (FY2024-25). Average inflation for 2024 (January-December) reached 10.34%, the highest in 13 years (since 11.40% in 2011). The Governor of Bangladesh Bank hopes that inflation will come down to 7% by June (2025) and below 5% by FY2025-26.

For 39 consecutive months, wage growth has been lower than inflation, meaning the real

income of ordinary people, especially the poor, has decreased. Inflation has been described as a type of "tax" on income. When wages cannot keep pace, people's ability to buy essential goods decreases, leading to financial pressure and a decline in living standards. This directly contributes to increasing poverty and inequality. The World Bank noted that three out of five households are breaking their savings to cope with financial pressure, indicating widespread financial distress and long-term impacts on household resilience and national savings rates. Prices of vegetables and food items remain high in the market due to damage to crop and vegetable production in flood-affected areas.

Despite efforts by Bangladesh Bank, inflation remains high, and the Finance Advisor blamed "wrong policies of the previous government" for this. The persistence of high inflation (average 10.34% in 2024, highest in 13 years) exists despite efforts to tighten monetary policy and normalize LC opening. This indicates that the problem is not merely demand-driven or supply-chain related. The ADB attributed it to "regulatory weaknesses, limited competition in wholesale markets, inadequate market information, supply chain constraints, and market inefficiencies caused by the depreciation of the Taka". This means that deeper structural issues such as lack of market oversight, syndicates, and exchange rate management are contributing to inflation, making it difficult to control with conventional monetary policy. Recent political instability and its impact on supply chains and market confidence may also be exacerbating inflationary pressures.

Investment and Trade Balance

A favorable investment environment is crucial for economic growth and job creation. However, Bangladesh faces challenges due to currency depreciation, import restrictions, and trade imbalances. The Business Environment Index (BBS) declined from 61.95 in 2022 to 58.75 in 2023, indicating a deterioration. The dollar exchange rate has recently risen from BDT 86 in May 2022 to BDT 118 (official), making investment decisions difficult. In the first eight months of FY2023-24, capital machinery imports decreased by 19% and raw material imports by 4-16%, indicating a weak investment situation. Private sector credit growth was at a 30-year low of 7.3% in December 2024.

The decline in the Business Environment Index, reduced imports of capital machinery and raw materials, and record-low private sector credit growth paint a discouraging picture for investment. The primary drivers appear to be the 'dollar crisis' and rapid depreciation of the Taka, which make imports expensive and affect expected returns on investment. However, the underlying problems are deeper: "political instability" and "lack of good governance and corruption" are explicitly cited as investment barriers. This indicates a vicious cycle where instability and weak governance hinder investment, which in turn limits job creation and economic growth, potentially fueling further social and political discontent.

Regarding the trade balance, Bangladesh's exports were \$52 billion and imports were \$82.49 billion in 2021-22, resulting in a significant trade deficit. The current account deficit decreased by \$1.1 billion due to increased remittances and garment exports. However, bilateral trade between Bangladesh and India is highly imbalanced: while Bangladesh imported \$9 billion worth of goods from India last fiscal year, it exported only \$1.57 billion. New Indian restrictions have further exacerbated this imbalance. The ADB warned that exports could face further pressure from additional US tariffs and a potential economic slowdown in key markets. The IMF emphasized strengthening good governance and transparency to improve the business environment and attract FDI. While increased remittances and garment exports have helped reduce the current account deficit, reliance on a single export sector (ready-made garments,

83% of total exports) makes the economy vulnerable to external shocks such as tariffs or market downturns. The trade imbalance with India, exacerbated by new restrictions, highlights the need for stronger trade diplomacy and diversification of export markets and products. This means that while short-term measures like increased remittances are helpful, long-term stability requires structural reforms to boost export competitiveness and reduce import dependence.

Budget and Foreign Debt

Bangladesh heavily relies on domestic and foreign loans to finance its budget deficit. The budget deficit for FY2024-25 is BDT 2.56 trillion. The government has proposed borrowing BDT 1.375 trillion from banks. The tendency to repay old debts with new loans and the proposal to borrow a large amount from banks indicate a growing reliance on debt for fiscal deficit management. This suggests a potential risk of falling into a debt trap if revenue collection does not significantly improve. The high budget deficit and increasing reliance on budget support from international lenders imply a structural weakness in domestic resource mobilization.

Bangladesh is receiving \$1.4 billion in budget support from the World Bank and ADB for FY2024-25. Total budget support commitments for FY2023-24 are expected to be \$2.6 billion, the highest in Bangladesh's history. To overcome the foreign exchange reserve crisis and ensure economic stability, Bangladesh is receiving \$3.5 billion in loans from the World Bank, IMF, and ADB. The IMF has increased its support by \$760 million, bringing the total ECF/EFF support to \$4.1 billion and RSF to \$1.3 billion.

The IMF has emphasized revenue reforms, reducing tax exemptions, controlling unnecessary expenditures, and cutting subsidies in the power sector. Due to Bangladesh's low tax-to-GDP ratio, the IMF highlighted the urgent need to create a fair, transparent, and simplified tax system to boost revenue. The significant loans received from the IMF, World Bank, and ADB are linked to conditions such as market-based exchange rates, financial reforms, and increased transparency in the banking sector. This indicates that international partners view underlying governance and structural issues as major impediments to Bangladesh's economic stability. The warning that the debt burden could become heavier if "transparency and fruitful expenditure" are not ensured emphasizes the importance of tackling corruption and mismanagement. This means that the effectiveness of these foreign funds in achieving economic stability and long-term growth depends on strong governance reforms and effective public financial management.

Employment Situation

Despite economic growth, Bangladesh faces significant challenges in creating sufficient and quality employment, especially for youth. The overall unemployment rate was 5.2% in 2021 (male 4.1%, female 7.9%). The labor force in 2021 was 70.96 million, with women comprising 31.1% and men 68.9%.

The unemployment rate increased from 4.15% in 2023 to 4.48% in 2024. In the October-December period of 2024, the unemployment rate was 4.63%, compared to 3.95% in the same period of 2023. The number of unemployed people reached 2.66 million in the third quarter of 2024, up from 2.49 million in 2023. The total labor force decreased by 3.5 million in one year, although it is unclear whether this is due to definition changes or an actual reduction. The youth unemployment rate is particularly high and rising, causing social discontent. The World Bank has forecast an increase in poverty due to labor market slowdown and job losses. The fact that economic growth has been "jobless" for nearly two decades, despite increased

exports and production in some sectors (e.g., ready-made garments), indicates a structural disconnect between economic expansion and job creation. This suggests that the nature of economic growth may be capital-intensive or highly productive in specific sectors, which are not generating widespread employment. The increasing share of the service sector in total employment could be a symptom of this, indicating a shift from labor-intensive manufacturing to higher-value service sectors, but failing to adequately absorb the labor force. This "jobless growth" exacerbates youth unemployment and social discontent, posing a significant risk of losing the "demographic dividend".

The recent increase in unemployment is directly linked to the "investment crisis", energy shortages, and high interest rates. This indicates that the economic challenges discussed earlier (deterioration of the investment climate, dollar crisis, high inflation) are directly translating into job losses and reduced employment opportunities. Factory closures due to these reasons create a negative feedback loop where economic downturns create unemployment, which in turn reduces purchasing power and further dampens demand, hindering economic recovery. Political instability also discourages investment, further worsening the employment situation.

3.2 Social Development and Human Resources

Social development and human resources are essential for Bangladesh's sustainable progress, but several significant challenges remain in this area.

Poverty and Inequality

Despite significant poverty reduction efforts, increasing inequality and economic shocks mean poverty remains a major challenge. In 2022, 18.7% of the population was below the poverty line; 5.6% were extremely poor. The World Bank forecasts that the national poverty rate will increase to 22.9% in 2025 (from 18.7% in 2022) and extreme poverty to 9.3% (from 7.7%), potentially creating an additional 3 million extremely poor people. This World Bank forecast indicates a reversal of previous poverty reduction trends. It is directly linked to the erosion of real income due to high inflation and job losses. This suggests that recent economic shocks (inflation, labor market slowdown) are disproportionately affecting the vulnerable, pushing more people into poverty.

Poverty is a deep and complex problem that affects economic and social development, reducing purchasing power, production, and economic growth, and hindering revenue collection. Poverty encourages social instability and crime. Income inequality between the rich and the poor is continuously increasing. The report explicitly links increasing inequality to structural problems such as unequal distribution of land and assets, lack of progressive taxation and social protection, concentration of economic and political power in the hands of elites, and regional disparities in development budget allocation. This means that economic growth alone is not sufficient to ensure inclusive development if there are no targeted policies to address wealth concentration and ensure equality of opportunity. The relationship between poverty and social instability/crime highlights broader social risks.

Corruption is a significant factor behind growing inequality. The explicit mention of corruption as "a significant factor behind growing inequality" provides a crucial causal link. It indicates that corruption, by allowing elites to capture economic and political benefits (subsidies, contracts, favorable policies), directly contributes to widening the wealth gap. This not only undermines economic efficiency but also exacerbates social inequality, making it difficult to achieve inclusive and sustainable development goals. Therefore, tackling corruption is not merely a governance

issue but a fundamental socio-economic imperative for Bangladesh's sustainable future.

Education and Healthcare

Bangladesh has made progress in increasing access to education and healthcare, but quality, equity, and affordability remain significant challenges. The literacy rate was 77.9% in 2023, up from 16.8% in 1971. Educational inclusion has significantly increased, but quality remains a concern. The budget allocation for the education sector in FY2024-25 was BDT 38,819 crore; a 20% increase has been demanded to ensure universal primary education. The enrollment rate in technical education is 17.2%, while 47% of educated individuals are unemployed. A 30% increase in the technical education budget has been demanded. While literacy rates and educational inclusion have increased, the emphasis on "quality education" and the high rate of "educated unemployed" indicate a serious mismatch between the outcomes of the education system and the demands of the labor market. This suggests that the current education system is likely too "bookish and knowledge-based" and lacks practical skill development. The demand for increased technical education directly addresses this issue, implying the need for more vocational and skill-based curricula to reduce unemployment among educated youth and meet industry demands.

In the healthcare sector, the budget for FY2024-25 was BDT 90,959 crore. However, over 68% of healthcare expenditure is out-of-pocket. Modern healthcare is expanding through telemedicine platforms (e.g., Sheba, Doctorola). Healthcare challenges include social and geographical disparities (urban vs. rural access), high costs, shortage of trained nurses and technologists, mismanagement, and corruption in government hospitals. The stark contrast in healthcare access between urban and rural areas and the high rate of out-of-pocket expenditure reveal deep inequalities and a significant financial burden on citizens. This suggests that despite advances in modern medicine and telemedicine, their benefits are not reaching the majority of people, especially the rural poor. "Mismanagement and corruption" in government hospitals further undermine public trust and the effectiveness of healthcare delivery, linking to broader governance challenges.

Human Resource Development and Digital Transformation

Digital transformation is a cornerstone of Bangladesh's development strategy, aiming to leverage technology for human resource development and economic growth. Information Technology (IT) education plays a special role in human resource development, contributing to acquiring technological skills and overall economic and social development. E-learning and online education are expanding, making education more accessible. Digital healthcare, online banking, and mobile payments improve living standards. Government policies and incentives support IT education and investment in the IT sector.

"Vision 2041" aims to transform Bangladesh into a developed and smart country through indigenous technology innovation and use. The importance of indigenous technology includes increasing self-reliance, economic growth, social development, and national security. Steps for indigenous technology development include increased investment in research and development, creation of skilled human resources (STEM), improved infrastructure (high-speed internet, data centers), private sector participation, and public awareness. Emerging technologies (Artificial Intelligence, Internet of Things, Blockchain, Virtual Reality/Augmented Reality, Robotics, Biotechnology, Nanotechnology) bring opportunities as well as challenges, such as privacy, ethics, digital divide, job displacement, and cybersecurity.

Internet penetration is rapidly increasing, but disparities and infrastructural limitations are prominent. 97% of the country's fiber optic cables are concentrated in urban areas, and satellite internet usage is limited. Despite the emphasis on digital transformation and IT education, this severe digital divide poses a significant barrier to inclusive human resource development. This suggests that the benefits of digital education, healthcare, and economic opportunities often remain out of reach for people in rural and remote areas, exacerbating existing social inequalities and limiting the full realization of the "Smart Bangladesh" vision. Solutions like Starlink offer potential for digital connectivity and disaster management in rural and remote areas, but face regulatory, economic, and data sovereignty challenges. Digital inclusion can benefit women, indigenous people, and persons with disabilities.

The emphasis on indigenous technology in "Vision 2041" is crucial not only for economic growth but also for national security and reducing dependence on foreign technology, especially in sensitive areas like software. This indicates that reliance on foreign technology carries risks of data access and national security vulnerabilities. Developing local expertise and production capabilities in STEM fields is vital not only for economic self-reliance and job creation but also for protecting national interests in an increasingly digital and connected world. This is a forward-looking strategy that addresses long-term geopolitical and economic resilience.

3.3 Political and Governance Situation

Political stability and good governance are the foundations of sustainable development for any country. Bangladesh has faced significant challenges in both these areas recently.

Recent Political Transition

On August 5, 2024, the former Prime Minister resigned following unprecedented protests. An interim government led by civil society members and student leaders took office on August 8, 2024. This political unrest disrupted economic activities in the industrial and service sectors. The political instability, which led to the resignation of the former Prime Minister and the formation of an interim government, was not confined to the political arena. Its disruption of economic activities in the industrial and service sectors, deterioration of law and order, and incidents of vandalism and arson indicate that political instability directly undermines economic performance and social stability. More than a hundred laborers were among the martyrs of the popular uprising, suggesting deep socio-economic discontent behind these protests, linking political instability to underlying issues of inequality and economic hardship.

During this period, there were "three days without a government" and a kind of "leadership crisis" and "widespread deterioration of law and order" in the administration. Incidents of vandalism, arson, and looting occurred at Awami League party offices and many homes of party leaders and activists in Dhaka and various districts. Mobile internet connectivity was unavailable in various parts of the country. This period of uncertainty, coupled with mobile internet disruption, likely eroded public trust in state institutions and the government's ability to maintain basic services and security. These events highlight the critical need for strong, resilient governance systems that can withstand political shocks and ensure continuity of essential functions.

Good Governance and Corruption

Corruption is a pervasive problem for Bangladesh, undermining good governance and hindering

national development. In Transparency International's (TI) 2024 Corruption Perception Index (CPI), Bangladesh scored only 23 out of 100, one point less than in 2023. As a result, Bangladesh's position dropped two places to 151st compared to last year. This is Bangladesh's worst score since 2012. This score indicates that the corruption situation is not merely isolated incidents but is worsening.

According to TI's report, the highest level of corruption occurs at the administrative level, especially in the service sector, where ordinary people are virtually held hostage. This concentration of corruption at the administrative level and in the service sector directly affects ordinary citizens, creating a system where basic services are held hostage. This widespread corruption is clearly linked to growing inequality, as it allows elites to capture economic and political benefits. This suggests that corruption is not merely a symptom of underdevelopment but a fundamental barrier to inclusive growth and social justice.

The Anti-Corruption Commission (ACC) is the only recognized independent, impartial, and autonomous body established in Bangladesh to suppress, control, and prevent corruption. It became effective under the Anti-Corruption Commission Act, 2004, which was amended in 2013 and 2016. The ACC Rules were amended in 2007 and 2019. The functions of the ACC include conducting inquiries and investigations into scheduled offenses, filing and prosecuting cases under the Act, and conducting promotional activities for corruption prevention (e.g., anti-corruption committees, integrity units, public hearings, publications).

Although the ACC operates as an independent body, the deterioration of the CPI score raises questions about the effectiveness of current anti-corruption efforts. While the ACC has taken on numerous cases and is trying to perform its duties effectively, the persistence of high levels of corruption indicates that structural issues, possibly a lack of political will, enforcement capacity, or accountability at higher levels, remain unresolved. The World Bank's October 2024 report cited "weak governance and transparency" as structural problems. The IMF also emphasized strengthening good governance and transparency to improve the business environment and attract Foreign Direct Investment (FDI). This highlights that international partners also view this as a critical area for Bangladesh's economic future.

3.4 Environmental Challenges and Climate Change

Bangladesh is one of the most climate-vulnerable countries in the world, constantly facing negative impacts on its climate behavior and natural balance due to increasing urbanization and industrialization.

Impacts of Climate Change

The impacts of climate change are most acutely felt in Bangladesh, severely affecting the country's environment and livelihoods. Key impacts include: decreased rainfall, increased salinity (especially in Khulna, Barguna, and Satkhira), abnormal temperatures, desertification, depletion of groundwater levels, scarcity of potable water, increased natural disasters (such as cyclones, tornadoes, tidal surges, permanent waterlogging, hailstorms, heavy rainfall and severe floods, river erosion, landslides, earthquakes), rising sea levels (increasing by about 3 mm annually, potentially displacing about 10 million people from coastal areas by 2050), depletion of natural resources (extinction or numerical variation of fish, animal, plant, and bird species), reduction or destruction of agricultural production, food insecurity, destruction of livelihoods, health risks (malnutrition, diseases), increase in climate refugees and human rights violations, social degradation, and economic losses.

This extensive list of climate change impacts, ranging from the displacement of millions due to rising sea levels to food insecurity and health risks, paints a picture of an existential threat. It is not merely an environmental problem but a multifaceted crisis affecting every aspect of human life and national development. The link between climate impacts and social degradation, human rights violations, and economic losses highlights the systemic nature of this challenge, requiring a holistic and urgent response. Climate change exacerbates existing socio-economic vulnerabilities, especially for the poor and marginalized. For example, reduced agricultural production and livelihood losses directly increase poverty and food insecurity, which are already major challenges. The creation of "climate refugees" puts further pressure on urban resources and infrastructure, leading to social unrest. This suggests that climate action must be integrated with broader development strategies, focusing on building resilience among the most vulnerable populations.

Climate Change Policies and Programs

The Government of Bangladesh has identified climate change as one of the most important issues in the country's development planning . To combat climate change risks, the Bangladesh Climate Change Strategy and Action Plan 2009 (BCCSAP-2009) was formulated by the government . To implement this plan, the Climate Change Trust Fund (CCTF) was established in FY2009-10 with the government's own funding . According to the provisions of the Climate Change Trust Act, 2010, the Bangladesh Climate Change Trust (BCCT) was formed on January 24, 2013, which is responsible for managing the Trust Fund . The functions of BCCT include project management, secretarial support, awareness building, and research . In 2015, the Honorable Prime Minister was awarded the "Champions of the Earth" medal by the United Nations for her strong leadership in climate change . Recently, the "Ministry of Environment and Forest" was renamed "Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change" .

The establishment of BCCSAP and CCTF demonstrates a strong policy commitment to climate change. However, the continuously severe impacts indicate potential gaps in the scale or effectiveness of implementation. While the government acknowledges the problem, the sheer magnitude of the challenge, combined with existing governance issues, may hinder comprehensive action. This suggests that while policies exist, there is a critical need for increased capacity, transparent resource allocation, and effective implementation to translate policy into real resilience.

The Asian Development Bank (ADB) has emphasized digital transformation, increased climate resilience, and regional connectivity . Bangladesh has called for support in environmentally friendly investment, technical training, river restoration, private sector engagement, cybersecurity, and joint research. Innovative solutions include sustainable brick kiln solutions (optimized stacking, biomass fuel, heat retention, continuous coal feeding) . The focus on innovative solutions like sustainable brick kilns and the call for international assistance for environmentally friendly investment and technical training highlight the need for both local innovation and global partnerships. This suggests that a multi-pronged approach, combining indigenous innovation with international financial and technological assistance, is essential for building long-term climate resilience. The emphasis on digital transformation for climate data analysis and early warning systems further underscores the role of technology in adaptation strategies.

3.5 Infrastructural Limitations

Robust infrastructure is essential for sustainable economic growth and social development. While Bangladesh has made significant investments in this area, some limitations still exist.

Power Sector

Despite increased power generation capacity, the power sector faces significant financial losses, rising production costs, and discrepancies between declared and actual capacity. By the end of 2024, the country's total power generation capacity is expected to reach 31,000 megawatts. In 2023, the daily maximum average generation was 13,208 megawatts, and the minimum was 9,608 megawatts. The Bangladesh Power Development Board (BPDB) incurred a loss of BDT 117.65 billion in FY2022-23. The average cost per unit of electricity production increased from BDT 8.84 to BDT 11.33. Electricity prices are being increased repeatedly to reduce losses. Although the country's declared power generation capacity is approximately 26,000 megawatts, the actual capacity is not more than 21,000 megawatts, with an additional 3,000 megawatts of captive power and 500 megawatts of off-grid renewable energy.

BPDB's significant losses and rising per-unit production costs indicate a financially unstable power sector. Repeated price hikes, despite failing to cover losses, impose an increasing burden on consumers, contributing to inflation and reduced purchasing power. This suggests that the problem is not just about generation capacity but also about the sector's efficiency, governance, and cost-recovery mechanisms. The discrepancy between declared and actual capacity also points to inefficiencies or underutilization of existing infrastructure. The government has allocated BDT 100 crore as special funding in FY2024-25 to promote the development and use of renewable energy, aiming to build a "Smart Bangladesh" by 2041. This is a positive step towards long-term energy security and sustainability. It suggests that sole reliance on fossil fuels is unsustainable both economically (due to price volatility and import dependence) and environmentally. Shifting towards renewable energy can help reduce BPDB's losses, stabilize energy costs, and contribute to climate resilience, aligning with the "Smart Bangladesh" vision.

Communication and Transport

Bangladesh has invested heavily in infrastructure, particularly in transport, but faces challenges in project implementation and maintenance. Over the past 15 years (2009-2024), the transport and communication sector has received the highest allocation (17-28%) in the Annual Development Program. Significant mega-projects in the country include the Matarbari Power Plant (which will provide deep sea channel facilities for Cox's Bazar and Moheshkhali), the Jamuna Bangabandhu Railway Bridge (the country's longest dual-gauge double-track railway bridge, connecting North Bengal, to be completed by August 2024), and the Padma Bridge Rail Link (Dhaka-Bhanga railway inaugurated in 2023, to be extended from Dhaka to Jessore by June 2024, and then Khulna Express will go directly from Dhaka via Padma Bridge to Kolkata). Rural infrastructure development projects are ongoing in Dhaka and Joypurhat districts. However, governance challenges exist in the implementation of road and highway development projects. These include a lack of region-specific designs, insufficient heavy machinery for contractors, and unclear maintenance policies. While mega-projects like Matarbari, Jamuna Bangabandhu Railway Bridge, and Padma Bridge Rail Link are crucial for national connectivity and economic integration, existing challenges in rural infrastructure development, such as the lack of region-specific road designs and insufficient heavy machinery for contractors, indicate a disconnect between high-level vision and on-the-ground implementation quality. This suggests

that while large-scale projects grab headlines, the effectiveness of basic infrastructure development crucial for local economies and daily life is hampered by practical implementation issues and potential governance gaps. The ambiguity in maintenance policies for local infrastructure (roads, bridges, culverts) raises concerns about the long-term sustainability of these projects and the return on investment. Without proper maintenance, newly built infrastructure can rapidly deteriorate, negating development gains. This suggests that robust policy frameworks, clear responsibilities, and adequate funding for post-construction maintenance are needed to ensure the longevity and effectiveness of infrastructure investments.

4. Solutions and Future Actions

To overcome Bangladesh's current challenges and move towards sustainable development, a coordinated and multi-dimensional approach is required.

4.1 Economic Stability and Growth

- **Controlling Inflation:** It is crucial to implement a strict monetary policy to control inflation. Additionally, structural issues such as market inefficiencies, supply chain bottlenecks, and regulatory weaknesses must be identified and addressed. Market monitoring should be strengthened to prevent syndicates, and exchange rate management needs to be rationalized. This will stabilize prices and restore the purchasing power of people, especially those with low incomes.
- **Improving Investment Climate:** Effective measures must be taken to address the dollar crisis and Taka depreciation. Business regulations should be simplified, uninterrupted supply of gas and electricity ensured, bank interest rates reduced, and cooperation from the banking sector increased. Attracting domestic and foreign investment will be possible by curbing corruption and ensuring good governance. This will accelerate industrial growth and create employment opportunities.
- **Trade Balance and Export Diversification:** Strong trade diplomacy is needed to address issues like the trade imbalance with India and new restrictions. It is essential to diversify export products beyond the ready-made garment sector and explore new markets. Rationalizing the import tariff structure is also necessary. This will reduce the trade deficit, increase foreign exchange reserves, and enhance the economy's resilience against external shocks.
- **Revenue Collection and Fiscal Discipline:** A fair, transparent, and simplified tax system must be implemented to increase the tax-to-GDP ratio. Reducing tax exemptions, increasing tax compliance, and clearly separating tax policy from administration are necessary. Controlling unnecessary expenditures and rationalizing subsidies in sectors like power are essential. This will reduce reliance on debt and create sufficient financial resources for social spending and infrastructure development.

4.2 Inclusive Social Development

- **Poverty and Inequality Eradication:** Targeted social safety net programs must be strengthened to alleviate poverty. Ensuring equitable distribution of land and assets and implementing progressive tax policies are necessary. Strict measures against corruption are needed to prevent the concentration of wealth in the hands of elites. The Palli Daridra

Bimochon Foundation (PDBF) plays a significant role in rural poverty alleviation and women's empowerment through its microcredit, women entrepreneur loans, small and cottage industry loans, agricultural livelihood loans, various savings schemes, and training programs. Such initiatives need to be further expanded. This will reduce poverty, decrease income inequality, and enhance social stability.

- **Education and Human Resource Development:** Priority must be given to ensuring quality education, not just inclusion. Curriculum reform is needed to make the education system more skill-based and practical. Investment in technical and vocational education (including STEM fields) must be increased, and the existing gap between the education system and labor market demands must be bridged. This will enhance human resource skills, reduce educated unemployment, and meet industrial demands.
- **Healthcare Quality and Access:** Modern medical facilities must be expanded to marginalized and rural areas, especially in community clinics and upazila health complexes. Health insurance should be introduced for the poor and low-income people, and the quality and number of nursing and paramedic educational institutions must be increased. Transparency and accountability must be ensured in public healthcare, and corruption in the health sector must be curbed. This will ensure affordable and equitable healthcare for all and improve the public health system.

4.3 Establishing Good Governance and Combating Corruption

- **Political Stability and Democratic Process:** An environment for inclusive political dialogue must be created, and democratic institutions must be strengthened. Establishing the rule of law and increasing public trust in state processes are crucial. This will create a predictable and stable environment for development and investment.
- **Combating Corruption:** Institutions like the Anti-Corruption Commission (ACC) must be strengthened, and their independence and effectiveness ensured. Strict laws and policies must be implemented to combat corruption and money laundering. Transparency and accountability in public administration and service delivery must be increased. This will reduce corruption, improve the quality of public services, and increase investor confidence.

4.4 Climate Resilience and Environmental Protection

- **Adaptation and Mitigation:** The Bangladesh Climate Change Strategy and Action Plan 2009 (BCCSAP 2009) must be effectively implemented, and the Climate Change Trust Fund (CCTF) strengthened. Investment in climate-resilient infrastructure such as flood-resistant housing, embankments, and cyclone shelters must be increased. Early warning systems should be improved, and climate-friendly technologies like sustainable brick kilns and renewable energy encouraged. This will reduce vulnerability to climate change impacts, protect livelihoods, and ensure food security.
- **International Cooperation:** Active collaboration with international partners (ADB, IMF, World Bank) is essential for climate finance, technological assistance, and knowledge exchange. Bangladesh's leadership in climate adaptation should be leveraged. This will ensure the necessary resources and expertise for large-scale climate action.

4.5 Infrastructural Development and Digital Transformation

- **Power Sector Reform:** To reduce the financial losses of the Bangladesh Power Development Board (BPDB), measures must be taken to increase efficiency, implement cost-reflective pricing, and reduce system losses. Diversifying the energy mix and increasing investment in renewable energy sources are necessary to reduce import dependence. This will ensure a sustainable and affordable power supply for industrial and domestic use.
- **Communication Infrastructure:** Mega-projects must be completed on time while maintaining quality. Region-specific designs for rural roads should be prioritized, adequate heavy machinery for contractors ensured, and clear and adequately funded maintenance policies formulated for all infrastructure. This will improve communication systems, facilitate trade, and enhance rural-urban connectivity.
- **Digital Inclusion and Indigenous Technology Development:** To bridge the digital divide, high-speed internet and fiber optic networks must be expanded in rural and remote areas. Indigenous technology innovation should be encouraged through increased investment in research and development, promoting STEM education, increasing private sector participation, and raising public awareness. Regulatory and economic barriers for emerging technologies like satellite internet must be removed. This will foster a knowledge-based economy, create new jobs, enhance national security, and improve the quality of public services.

5. Conclusion and Recommendations

Bangladesh's current situation faces a complex set of challenges, where economic pressures, social inequalities, lack of good governance, and the impacts of climate change are intricately linked. High inflation is eroding people's purchasing power and increasing poverty, indicating structural weaknesses and policy ineffectiveness. The deteriorating investment climate and jobless growth threaten economic stability, closely related to political instability and corruption. Climate change-induced disasters further exacerbate the country's vulnerability, hindering the achievement of long-term development goals.

Addressing these challenges requires a coordinated and holistic approach. The recommendations derived from this report's analysis are as follows:

1. **Strengthening Macroeconomic Stability:**
 - **Inflation Control:** Bangladesh Bank must strictly implement monetary policy and strengthen market monitoring to eliminate syndicates and supply chain bottlenecks. The Taka exchange rate must be aligned with market forces and its stability ensured.
 - **Increased Revenue Collection and Fiscal Discipline:** A comprehensive tax reform program must be implemented to increase the tax-to-GDP ratio, prioritizing reduced tax exemptions and increased tax compliance. Controlling unnecessary government expenditure and rationalizing subsidies in critical sectors like power are essential.
 - **Attracting Investment and Export Diversification:** The business environment must be improved, including ensuring energy supply, reducing bank interest rates, and addressing the dollar crisis. New export products and markets beyond the ready-made garment sector must be explored, and trade diplomacy strengthened.
2. **Ensuring Inclusive Social Development:**
 - **Poverty and Inequality Eradication:** Targeted social safety net programs must be

expanded to alleviate poverty, and equitable distribution of wealth and opportunities ensured. Initiatives by institutions like the Palli Daridra Bimochon Foundation (PDBF) for rural poverty alleviation and women's empowerment should be further strengthened.

- **Education and Human Resource Development:** Priority must be given to quality and practical skills in the education system to align with labor market demands. Investment in technical and vocational education should be increased, and special programs adopted to reduce educated unemployment by enhancing skills.
- **Healthcare Equity and Affordability:** Modern medical facilities must be expanded to rural and remote areas, and affordable health insurance introduced for all. The quality of nursing and paramedic educational institutions should be improved to address human resource shortages.

3. **Establishing Good Governance and Accountability:**

- **Combating Corruption:** Institutions like the Anti-Corruption Commission (ACC) must be strengthened, and their independence and effectiveness ensured. Strict laws against corruption and money laundering must be enforced. Transparency and accountability in administration and public services should be increased, which will boost investor confidence and reduce resource wastage.
- **Political Stability:** An inclusive political environment must be created, and democratic institutions strengthened. Long-term stability can be ensured by establishing the rule of law and restoring public trust.

4. **Climate Resilience and Environmental Protection:**

- **Adaptation and Mitigation:** Effective implementation of the Bangladesh Climate Change Strategy and Action Plan (BCCSAP) is crucial. Investment in climate-resilient infrastructure, improved early warning systems, and increased investment in renewable energy and environmentally friendly technologies are necessary.
- **International Cooperation:** Active collaboration with international partners for climate finance and technology transfer is essential.

5. **Infrastructural Development and Digital Transformation:**

- **Power Sector Reform:** To reduce the financial losses of the power sector, efficiency must be increased, system losses reduced, and investment in renewable energy sources expanded.
- **Communication Infrastructure:** Mega-projects must be completed on time and with quality. Region-specific designs for rural infrastructure and proper maintenance policies must be ensured.
- **Digital Inclusion:** To bridge the digital divide, high-speed internet must be expanded in rural areas. Increased investment in research and development for indigenous technology innovation and promotion of STEM education are crucial.

The collective efforts of the government, private sector, civil society, and international partners are essential for implementing these recommendations. These steps will play a crucial role in building a stable, inclusive, and climate-resilient Bangladesh.

যেসব কাজের উদ্ধৃতি যোগ করা হয়েছে

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0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A8%E0%A6%AC-%E0%A6%B8%E0%A6%AE%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%AA%E0%A6%A6-%E0%A6%89%E0%A6%A8%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%A8%E0%A6%AF%E0%A6%BC%E0%A6%A8%E0%A7%87-%E0%A6%A4%E0%A6%A5%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%AF-%E0%A6%AA%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%B0%E0%A6%AF%E0%A7%81%E0%A6%95%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%A4%E0%A6%BF-%E0%A6%B6%E0%A6%BF%E0%A6%95%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%B7%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%B0-%E0%A6%97%E0%A7%81%E0%A6%B0%E0%A7%81%E0%A6%A4%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%AC-%E0%A6%A8%E0%A6%BF%E0%A6%B0%E0%A7%82%E0%A6%AA%E0%A6%A3-%E0%A6%95%E0%A6%B0%E0%A7%81%E0%A6%A8-WgcwIQK-GPVZwggg 30. বাংলাদেশে জলবায়ু পরিবর্তনের প্রভাব - উইকিপিডিয়া, https://bn.wikipedia.org/wiki/%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%82%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B6%E0%A7%87_%E0%A6%9C%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%AF%E0%A6%BC%E0%A7%81_%E0%A6%AA%E0%A6%B0%E0%A6%BF%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%B0%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%A4%E0%A6%A8%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B0_%E0%A6%AA%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%B0%E0%A6%AD%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%AC 31. বাংলাদেশে ইটভাটা দূষণ মোকাবিলায় টেকসই সমাধান উদ্ভাবন - গ্রীন পেইজ, <https://greenpage.com.bd/%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%82%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B6%E0%A7%87-%E0%A6%87%E0%A6%9F%E0%A6%AD%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%9F%E0%A6%BE-%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%82%E0%A6%B7%E0%A6%A3-%E0%A6%AE%E0%A7%8B/> 32. বাংলাদেশের মেগা প্রকল্পের তালিকা - উইকিপিডিয়া, https://bn.wikipedia.org/wiki/%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%82%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B0_%E0%A6%AE%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%97%E0%A6%BE_%E0%A6%AA%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%B0%E0%A6%95%E0%A6%B2%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%AA%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B0_%E0%A6%A4%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BF%E0%A6%95%E0%A6%BE 33. ২০২৪-২০২৫ অর্থ বছরের বার্ষিক উন্নয়ন কর্মসূচি, https://adp.plancomm.gov.bd/exp/press-book.php?&fiscal_year=2024&ceiling_for=0&group=sector&action=demand&funding=gob&lang=bn&view=html&pageno=1&project_type=1§or=8&sub_sector=0&ministry=0 34. বাংলাদেশে বৈষম্য বাড়ছে, ঠেকানোর পথ কী - প্রথম আলো, <https://www.prothomalo.com/anniversary/pahpkrl6wx> 35. দূর্নীতি দমন কমিশন (বাংলাদেশ) - উইকিপিডিয়া, [https://bn.wikipedia.org/wiki/%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%81%E0%A6%B0%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%A8%E0%A7%80%E0%A6%A4%E0%A6%BF_%E0%A6%A6%E0%A6%AE%E0%A6%A8_%E0%A6%95%E0%A6%AE%E0%A6%BF%E0%A6%B6%E0%A6%A8_\(%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%82%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B6\)](https://bn.wikipedia.org/wiki/%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%81%E0%A6%B0%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%A8%E0%A7%80%E0%A6%A4%E0%A6%BF_%E0%A6%A6%E0%A6%AE%E0%A6%A8_%E0%A6%95%E0%A6%AE%E0%A6%BF%E0%A6%B6%E0%A6%A8_(%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%82%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B6)) 36. বিশ্বব্যাংক ও এডিবি থেকে ১৪০ কোটি ডলার বাজেট সহায়তা পাচ্ছে ..., <https://sharenews24.com/article/102779/index.html> 37. শিক্ষা খাতে বিনিয়োগ বাড়লেই মানবসম্পদের দক্ষতা বাড়বে না | প্রথম আলো, <https://www.prothomalo.com/opinion/column/ghloscbowc> 38. শিক্ষা খাতে বাজেটের মোট জিডিপি ৬ শতাংশ বরাদ্দসহ ২০ দফা দাবি - Amar Barta, <https://www.amarbartta.com/politics/50252> 39. কেন্দ্রীয় বাজেট ২০২৪-২৫-এ সামাজিক অগ্রাধিকার: একনজরে - Observer Research Foundation, <https://www.orfonline.org/bangla/expert-speak/-social-priorities-in-the-union-budget-2024-25-a-snapshot> 40. অগ্রাধিকার ভিত্তিতে গুরুত্বপূর্ণ পল্লী অবকাঠামো উন্নয়ন প্রকল্প-২ (১ম সংশোধিত), https://imed.portal.gov.bd/sites/default/files/files/imed.portal.gov.bd/page/7b67fc61_3eef_4cb0_b798_00fe28fa13af/IRIDP-2-Final-Report.pdf 41. উন্নত বাংলাদেশের চাবিকাঠি ২০২৪ সালের মেগা প্রকল্প - Gram Nagar Barta, <https://gramnagarbartta.com/news/%E0%A6%89%E0%A6%A8%E0%A7%8D%E0%A6%A8%E0%A6%A4-%E0%A6%AC%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%82%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B0-%E0%A6%9A%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%82%E0%A6%B2%E0%A6%BE%E0%A6%A6%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%B6>

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7%87%E0%A6%B0-%E0%A6%AE%E0%A7%87%E0%A6%97%E0%A6%BE-%E0%A6%AA%
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